

INTERVIEW | ANIL KUMBLE

"Dhoni's views will matter, but I will do my own thing"

India's newly-appointed Test captain Anil Kumble spoke to Deputy Editor SHARDA UGRA about the pitfalls and pleasures of his latest job.

Q. The team doesn't have a head coach. What help would you like to have in terms of support staff?

A. In terms of support staff we're pretty organised. In terms of a head coach, we have a cricket manager now, so that's good. I'm not thinking too much about it at the moment. It's always good to have someone at the head of the support staff, but I'm sure it will happen sooner or later.

Q. What's your take on the Tests against Pakistan?

A. We need to be focused. All India-Pak series are intense and it is important for us to start well. If we

can get the momentum early, we can try to dominate the series.

Q. You say your captaincy is a transitional leadership.

A. Yes, of course, I can't be playing for the next five-ten years. It has to be that the next crop of players who will have to take on from here and lead us to a better Indian team. It's important for the team to move forward and to ensure that we improve all the time and become more consistent. I hope I will take the team some way in that forward transition.

Q. From what you have seen, what is the toughest thing about being India captain?

A. It's the attention, the visibility. That's more of the issue than the ac-

tual decision-making on the field. On the field overall cricket has not changed much over the years. But the people who form opinions would previously keep it to themselves, or talk about it with you over a tea and beer. But now everything is public. Everything else seems to become more important. If the result is good then the supposed 'external factors' don't matter, if it's not good, then all other things seem to come into play.

Q. Do players have to change when they become captain?

A. I don't think so. I would rather do my own thing rather than worry about how everyone else judges me—people have always done that with my bowling... I will take people's opinions and viewpoints into account, especially Dhoni's as he is the ODI captain. His views will matter. But whatever decisions have to be taken, I will take them as I best think fit, on gut feeling if I have to.

Q. Most of the team you will lead is different in generation and in attitude too from your peers.

A. I look forward to that. Young India is definitely more confident, the way they come across to you, they are more confident, about themselves and their game. I have seen the transition in my years in the Indian team. I've had to change myself to cope with the transition, in areas like physical training to stay at par with these guys.

Merely thinking of two captains was sending out a gilt-edged invitation to chaos with free transport thrown in.

Today, though, the pundits are optimistic. Former captain M.A.K. Pataudi believes splitting the captaincy is "unnecessary", but says the fundamental "decency" of the men in question will see the Indians through.

Bishen Bedi, the last specialist bowler to lead India, thinks India will manage. Former pace bowler Javagal Srinath does not see any conflict. "It would have been unreasonable had

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NEW PARTNERSHIP:
Kumble (left) and Dhoni

Pakistan, but inside the selection committee, there appears to be a consensus that he will also lead the team to Australia, their trickiest assignment of the season. "We needed a tough man—specially for Australia," says a selector.

Kumble is both tough and adaptable. Never mind that jaw, little else about him is square. After a 17-year career largely about wickets and five-fers, this year he scored a maiden Test century and was named the Test captain in the space of three months. He was India's only centurion on a

successful Test tour of England and the captaincy too has come with its own twist. For the first time, India's leadership has been split, Kumble handling the Test team and M.S. Dhoni the men in blue pyjamas.

A few years ago the very idea would have given palpitations to Indian cricket's intelligentsia. Two captains had not worked in the game's holy land, Australia. How could India possibly find salvation in the idea? Our teams are supposed to be made up of rabbles and squabbles, boys rather than men.